



The 19 Laws of LinkedIn

[Click here for Google Doc \(Click File > Make a Copy\)](#)

Golden Idea

Your LinkedIn profile is a referral generation machine — 75%+ of your total referrals will come via LinkedIn, so you better make it incredible.

Importance

What's the main reason this idea is important to understand?

- Your LinkedIn profile is another point of asymmetric leverage. You can probably double your referral rate by maxing it out, and it's a one-time thing — so you need to do it as soon as possible.

To make a copy of this document go to File → Make a Copy.

Understandings

What are the key points of this video, the main things your audience should understand about it?

1. History of LinkedIn
2. It's Purpose
3. LinkedIn + Resume Combo
4. 500+ Connections
5. LinkedIn Premium
6. How To Create An Excellent Profile



History of LinkedIn

- Founded in December 2002 by Reid Hoffman — it's a social network aimed at professional development.
- 700+ Million Users as of 2024.
- Professional connections, career development, public resume.

Main Purpose

- LinkedIn is your warm lead generation machine. In a prior video, we discussed warm vs cold applications — warm applications occur when you have some contact with someone at the company.
 - System referral, hiring manager/recruiter email, informational interview to learn about the interview process.
- You acquire that warm lead/connection using LinkedIn. It's your greatest tool in the world of networking, so we need to fully optimize it as much as possible.
- That is the primary purpose of LinkedIn. Think of it as a magical little box that you walk up to, press a button, and out comes a referral. It's beautiful.
- But....most of you have broken machines.



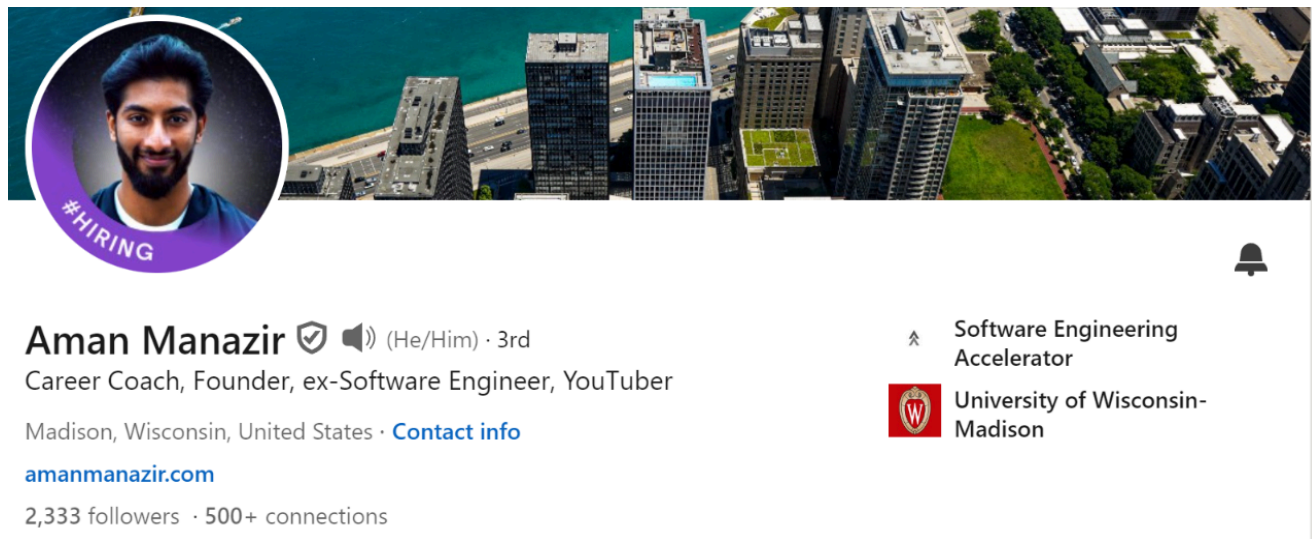
1. Your LinkedIn + Resume Come First

In the application process, all you have at the beginning are your LinkedIn and Resume. That's it — just those two elements determine whether you get the first interview or not and thus decide if you get the job.

Think about it — you can be the best at LeetCode on the planet, you could be Alan Turing or one of the best programmers on Earth, yet if you don't have a good resume and LinkedIn, YOU WILL NEVER GET HIRED.

Let that sink it.

Your first task in this program is to perfect both of these to the best of your ability, which is why I've placed this module first.



🤝 2. Get 500+ High Quality Connections

LinkedIn shows the number of connections publicly — our goal is over the next 6-12 months to grow this number to 500+.

High Quality Connections

- People who have worked at / are working at a company that you would like to work for.
- Not random people, nontechnical family friends, your friend from your dorm, etc.
- **Do not spam connect with people** — the goal is not 500 random connections, it's 500+ high quality connections.

If you already have 500+ connections, that's fine — chances are they're not very high quality. So still set the goal of increasing by 200-300 over the next 6 months.

A future video in the referral module will cover the tactics — how to find and get high quality connections.

The point: you can message connections.



🏆 3. Buy LinkedIn Premium (Currently \$239/Year)

LinkedIn Premium means you can send out unlimited connection requests, thus growing your network at a much faster pace.

This will more than pay for itself — it's a no brainer, high ROI.

Getting a job 1 day early already covers the cost. You need this now.

At a minimum, pay for it for 6 months until you get the internship/full time job and cancel — I recommend just having it, but if you absolutely need to cut down the cost, then only have it for 3-6 months before you get your offer.



● 4. Be Active on LinkedIn

- Treat others the way you want others to treat you.
- False Consensus Effect
 - If you give out referrals, accept connections, **actually reply to people**, and give out free information, you will start to expect that others do the same for you — and thus your behavior will change.

Trust me on this — if you want to grow your network, then *let other people grow theirs by connecting with you + responding to them.*

Comment + React to posts. Be an active consumer on the platform. People can see your activity and an active profile is a more attractive one that people want to connect with.

Allocate 15 mins/day to checking and being active on LinkedIn.

Even better, post on the platform. I know it can feel cringe when people post about their accomplishments — or at least I've seen it like that. But it does help. **Try to make a post once/month.** Post updates on the following. You want to seem like you're active, doing things in the SWE world. **Life/career lessons.**

1. Internships
2. Hackathons
 - a. Before, during, after
3. Research



5. Take a Beautiful Profile Photo

This is so important it's unimaginable, and is something people completely and utterly neglect.

Profile Photo Guidelines Checklist

- Recent (last 1-2 years)
- Looks like you — if someone meets you IRL, your profile photo should match how you look
- High quality image — no blurry, far away shots.
- Be the only person in the photo
- Have a happy, nice smile. Look vibrant, friendly, and alive.
- Have a clean, simple background
- Wear semi-professional clothing — you don't need a suit, but a dress shirt, sweater, something that looks decent.
- No selfies — someone else should take your photo.
- Take the photo in soft, natural light. Overcast days are great. Make sure the lighting isn't harsh and your face is illuminated. Morning / evening.
- Look as attractive as you possibly can. Be as good-looking as humanly possible.
 - If you're a girl and you wear makeup, then wear makeup.
 - If you're someone who likes to do your hair, then do your hair.
 - Why? Halo Effect!
 - Be professional, but look good.
- If you look overly young, then try to look older — if you're old, then try to look young. Aim for looking ~23-25.

AM

Advice on Getting a Good Profile Photo

Best: Hire a professional photographer or have a friend take a pro photo of you. It'll pay for itself, and is something you do every 1-2 years.

Okay: Have a friend (who's good at taking photos) go with you to a nice area and take an iPhone Portrait mode photo. Try to use a new iPhone.

1. Overcast, good lighting.
2. Dress well.
3. Take 50+ photos and pick the best one.

Do not take more than 5-7 days to get this done!

If you already have a great photo of you that you need to swap out, that's fine as well.





Quick tip: Make your profile picture public, so anyone should be able to see it.

Use An Aesthetic Banner

Halo effect.

Options:

- City landscape
- Campus shot
- Nature photo

You can get a stock image or search around on Google.

Pro tip: make sure the profile photo and banner contrast!

- Avoid warm on warm.



6. Body Rules

Headline

- Halo effect + Representativeness Heuristic (Bucket Principle)
- CS @ [University Name] | Software Engineering Intern @ Company
 - Consider abbreviation / expansion
 - Common formula — University + Current Role
- If you're a graduate, then have University + Graduation Date and then current role.
- Don't include technical terms in there — just bucket phrases.
- Don't add "Aspiring" — you don't want to come across as desperate. You are what you are.

Contact Info / Open To Work

- Have your contact information available (at least email).
 - Careers email — johnsmith10@gmail.com
- Make it public that you're open to work / what role.
 - If you're currently at a company, then make it only visible to recruiters.

About Section

You definitely need this, and you'll want to fill it out.

- Provide Examples
 - My Page
 - Aliyan
 - Navya

- Your first paragraph should again bucket you into what stage of life you are in. Be as confident as possible.
- The rest should discuss your unique life story + experience. You can often centralize your 'About' to cover a specific theme of Software Engineering.
 - Sarah
- 3-5 Paragraphs.

Featured

- Showcase any accomplishments you have.
- Research, Publications, Awards, Articles, etc.
- If you've created content or published in a journal or blog, this a good spot to show that.

Experience

- The most important section below the headline. **This is what you truly need to fill out completely.**
- Assignment: List out every work or job you've ever done in your life (few words each).
 - Yes, technical, non-technical, volunteering, research, clubs, internships, seminars, bootcamps, fellowships, events, ANYTHING.
 - Fast food, etc.
 - Of these roles, bold the technical ones that have something to do with STEM. If you have bolded more than 4 items, then only include the STEM work experience. If not, then include EVERYTHING you've ever done in your life.
 - More recent is better.
 - Add it all to your LinkedIn profile!
- Name the positions based on the resume guidelines that I provided — sell them to be as technical as possible.
- Every position needs a description, with no exceptions.
 - Specifically, you have the space to go into much more detail than your resume — there are no limits.
 - Minimum, copy and paste your resume description, but I don't like bullets.
 - I want to see 3-4 short paragraphs each explaining what you did in a narrative style + tangible results.
- First paragraph should explain 1) your role 2) what team 3) biggest project/most impressive achievement.
- Do not go light on this — it's something really worth investing in.

- Note: if you're lacking experience, treat most things as experience.
 - Club Positions, Research, Unpaid Internships, etc. Just sell it as an experience.
 - Info Week, Networking Event, Volunteering

Education

- Add all education.
- If you have a GPA above 3.5, you can also throw that on there.

Projects

- Add every project you've ever done in your life onto here. You can check your Resume list.
- Detailed descriptions.
- Link to website / GitHub

Volunteering

- Same as work experience — fill it in.

Skills

- Add every Skill you've ever worked with in your life.
 - Caveat: don't include weird nontechnical or technical skills or leadership
 1. Hard Worker, Focused, etc.
 2. Microsoft Office (unless you have under 10 skills)
- Connect to your work experience, so link the Skills you used in those positions.

Coursework

- Add every course you've ever taken (including nontechnical - if you have 10+ CS courses, then only include STEM).

Exams + Awards

- If you have good test scores, add those in (ACT, SAT, AP Exams).
- Achievements / Awards — if you've won any competition, hackathon, etc, make sure to add that in as well.

Languages



- Add any and all languages you're even semi-proficient in.

Skim through everything else you can possibly add + add that too.

KEEP IT UPDATED!!!